



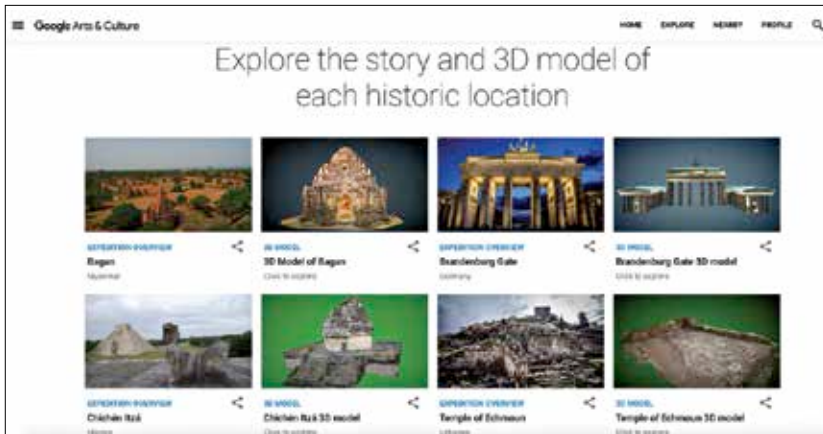
TikTok charity stickers

TikTok creators can now add new stickers to their videos through which viewers can donate to charities. <https://dgit.in/may20-53>



RetroPie 4.6 release

Retro game player RetroPie has released version 4.6 with Raspberry Pi 4 support. <https://dgit.in/may20-54>



Visit endangered, historical sites via Google Arts & Culture

teractive 3D tour of the now-destroyed temple. This will be launched in the Open Heritage Project. Alongside the Ananda Ok Kyaung temple, CyArk has captured 26 other locations from 18 countries such as Al Azem Palace in Damascus, the ruins of the Mayan city, Chichen Itza, the Roman city of Pompeii and more. Ben Kacyra, the founder of CyArk said that he was inspired to create the technology after seeing the destruction of 1,500-year-old Buddhist statues in Bamiyan, Afghanistan in 2001. The technology's end results are showcased on Google Arts & Culture, which previously only featured collections from museums. The partnership between CyArk and Google brought 3D heritage sites on the Google Arts & Culture platform for people to view from their computers or mobile devices. VR tours are supported on this platform on mobile phones too via Google's Daydream platform.

REANIMATING THE RUINS

There's only so much historians and museum curators can recreate through their written accounts and drawings. With the help of virtual reality, historical locations can be reanimated in the present. Australian archaeologist,

Simon Young, created Lithodomos VR which offers immersive reconstructions of historic sites or iconic ruins via a VR headset. Lithodomos VR is an app that can either be integrated into other VR technology such as the Oculus Rift or into customised VR headsets as part of on-site tours. The app tracks the user's location as well as their orientation and lets them explore virtual reconstructions dynamically, from all angles. Young envisions that this software will be useful for tour groups who provide VR headsets to their guests, as well as individual tourists using their own portable viewers.

As an example, take the Temple of Venus and Rome which is quite dilapidated today with most of its columns broken down. However, when you put on a VR headset with the Lithodomos app on-site, it is transformed into ancient-day Rome. The temple is whole once again with



Recreating Arènes de Lutèce, Paris, France.

its columns intact, allowing visitors to view the structure in its entirety. In addition to this temple, Lithodomos has also recreated the Arènes de Lutèce, a Roman amphitheatre and stage from 2nd century AD. In reality, the structure is now fragmented with parts of it tucked away behind apartment buildings in Paris' Latin Quarter. It also recreated the Odeon of Agrippa, a concert hall in the Athenian agora and some parts of ancient Jerusalem. Young plans on working on areas from Delphi, Spain and the UK in the future. As per Smithsonianmag, he also hopes to partner with museums and universities to create more VR experiences.

Hiverlab, a Singapore-based company, also works on digitizing ancient heritage sites all over the globe. They've created a VR tour of an Armenian church in Cypress originating in the medieval times. The tour allows visitors to wander around the structure today, while 'seeing' what exactly the structure looked like centuries ago.

OTHER VIRTUAL TOURS

Thanks to VR, travel is just a tap away even in times of lockdowns and self-quarantines. If you've run out of things to do at home, or you simply need a change of scenery, you can grab your laptop, tablet or mobile phone, and to make things even more immersive, a VR headset, and tour the world virtually. Sites such as the Louvre Museum in Paris, Machu Picchu in Peru, the National Museum of Computing, Milton Keynes, UK (for all you geeks), Georgia Aquarium in the USA, The Vatican in Rome, and numerous others are available to be seen digitally. There's also a site called indiavrtours.com which allows you to navigate through popular tourist destinations in India using a VR headset. The site features locations such as Fatehpur Sikri, the Lakshmi Narasimha at Hampi, Monkey Palace in Jaipur, Pushkar Camel Fair, numerous caves, forts, and of course, the Taj Mahal. **4**

Image source: Lithodomos